

first touchscreen technologies being developed. It's interesting to note that the first touchscreen displays were used in the field of air traffic control. However, these touchscreen displays remained largely unpopular as they offered little functionality in everyday use.

Putting the TV on a diet: Thinner, longer screens

The next revolution in the world of display technology was heralded by the arrival of personal computers. Screens now had to be made that could offer the users the option to interact with the images, which posed a new challenge: the images were no longer relayed by an external source, they were controlled precisely by each individual user. These requirements were addressed, along with a drastic improvement in quality, by the advent of Thin Film Transistor (TFT) LCD displays in the 1980s which were fitted onto some of the first large scale commercial PCs and laptops. These displays offered a wider range of colours and faster refresh rates as they were able to change the colour and display properties of each pixel on the screen in an 'active' manner. These are probably familiar to us. Remember the bulky monitors that we used to have in the early half of the last decade (or the ones that the State Bank of India still uses)? Those were 'thin' film transistors displays.

This period of TFT development also saw the rapid growth of the television industry. While televisions were a novelty even in the '70s, suddenly everyone and their grandmothers had TVs in the '80s. This competitive marketing between the different television manufacturers put the display on a diet and they grew thinner and taller every year. Touchscreen also became more and more common as many industries started adopting the technology into their products. ATMs introduced the world of touch technology to the common man and the first touch phones started appearing in the market. Plasma was slowly phased out and the definitive killing stroke was struck by the LCD with the arrival of the first HD TV stations in the USA in the late '90s. LCD displays for HD became cheaper, and, more importantly, larger than plasma.

LCD became the norm in the 2000s. Every display in the world, right from laptop screens at home to inbuilt entertainment systems on airlines whizzing at over 30,000 feet above sea level, were some variation of the LCD technology. HD started becoming more affordable as more broadcasting channels start viewing HD as the norm rather than as a special service. Apple's Retina display also debuted in the late 2000s along with their